





MR & MRS DON
(From far left) **Former MP Anand Mohan, his wife and ex-MP Lovely Anand with CM Nitish Kumar; Ashok Mahto with wife Kumari Anita in Munger; estranged RJD legislator Neelam Devi with ex-MLA Anant Singh**

on March 30, as he emerged from RJD chief Lalu Prasad Yadav's Patna residence, announcing that his wife Annu would contest from the Vaishali LS seat. However, when the RJD released its list of 22 candidates on April 9, it was the three-time MLA from Lalganj who had been given the ticket, not his wife. The Bihar strongman, who has been acquitted in at least two murder cases, will be taking on Lok Janshakti Party (LJP) MP Veena Devi, who is once again NDA's candidate there.

And lest one think Lalu's party alone is partial to musclemen, now friend, now rival Janata Dal (United) is also not averse to enlisting 'influential figures' to the cause. And so, Bihar chief minister Nitish Kumar has extended a 'spousal visa' to Lovely Anand, wife of former MP Anand Mohan Singh, to contest the Sheohar Lok Sabha seat. Anand Mohan, who terrorised the Saharsa-Supaul belt for decades, is a polarising figure celebrated among his Rajput brethren and reviled by the lower castes. The National Democratic Alliance (NDA) has also welcomed former RJD legislator Neelam Devi, wife of convicted politician Anant Singh. Spousal luck, however, ran out on Sharada Devi, wife of Naxalite leader Ajay Kanu, convicted in the 2005 Jehanabad jailbreak case. Kanu tried for an RJD ticket for his wife during a visit to Lalu's residence on March 27, but the party, it turns out, has fielded Surendra Prasad from Jehanabad instead.

Part Robin Hood, part caste lords, part social influencers, and mostly musclemen, these figures mirror the intricate entanglement of personal and caste histories, criminal legacies and political ambition that are a characteristic of the political landscape in Bihar. Defying predictions of their waning influence after the 2019 Lok Sabha election, Bihar's dons are seeing a resurgence in their 'popularity', with both alliances seeking their patronage in the electoral battlefield. ■





THIRD IN LINE **Congress's Shreyas Patel (left) will take on Prajwal Revanna, scion of JD(S) first family, in Hassan**

wrested away by the late G. Puttaswamy Gowda, also from Holenarasipura. The families have long been political rivals. That rivalry is now carried into the third generation: facing Prajwal in a straight fight in Hassan is Puttaswamy Gowda's grandson Shreyas M. Patel, the Congress nominee.

For Shreyas, 32, it's the second such face-off with the JD(S) first family. In the May 2023 assembly election, he had squared off with Prajwal's father, H.D. Revanna, in Holenarasipura and lost by a mere 3,152 votes. At Shukravarasanthe village on April 11, Patel makes an emotional appeal. "I lost my last election, my mother has lost two elections. Vote for a change this time," he says.

In Malali the same day, JD(S) patriarch Deve Gowda strikes an equally emotive chord. "Who have I wronged?" he asks, reminding voters that it was he who made Puttaswamy Gowda, Shreyas's grandfather, a member of the Karnataka Legislative Council in 1978. Deve Gowda then turns his focus to Karnataka chief minister Siddaramaiah and Deputy CM D.K. Shivakumar, whom he accuses of targeting the three Lok Sabha seats his party is contesting (poll ally BJP is contesting the other 25). Besides Prajwal in Hassan, Gowda's son H.D. Kumaraswamy is standing from neighbouring Mandya. In Kolar, the JD(S) has nominated local leader Mallesh Babu.

In Hassan, which votes on April 26, the Deve Gowda family is banking on its track record of development activities—Prajwal's father Revanna is the MLA from Holenarasipura; younger sibling Suraj Revanna is a member of the legislative council.

"It's a tough fight," admits a Congress worker. "But we have a good candidate." Of the eight assembly segments in the Hassan Lok Sabha seat, the JD(S) holds four while the BJP and Congress have two each. The Congress is looking to gain from fierce local rivalries between allies JD(S) and the BJP. For the latter, the big task is to get their party workers to work in tandem. ■